

Q How can I make sure my baby is latched onto the breast correctly?

The key to successful breast-feeding—feeding that is comfortable for you and ensures your baby gets sufficient milk—is to position your baby well on the breast. There is an art to getting your little one “latched on” properly. You may not get it right until you have breast-fed a few times, but give yourself time and seek support if necessary.

Why a good latch is important

When your baby isn't latched on correctly, she will drag on your nipple rather than massage your breast tissue with her sucking. The result is sore and cracked nipples and possibly problems with milk supply, since your baby's weak sucking may not be stimulating your breasts to make enough milk. If your baby isn't

emptying your breast properly, it also increases your risk of developing complications, such as mastitis (see pp.274–75), because breast milk can stagnate in the ducts and become infected.

The nurses at the hospital will help and advise you. You can also find help with breast-feeding organizations and from breast-feeding consultants.

A STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE TO LATCHING ON

Get as comfortable as possible before you begin a feeding. Choose a chair that supports your lower back, and use cushions for additional support of your back and arms if this helps. Specially designed U-shaped feeding cushions that support your baby can be helpful, especially after a cesarean section, since they bear the weight of your baby and thereby avoid putting pressure on your scar.



1 HOLD YOUR BABY NOSE TO NIPPLE
Position your baby facing you (“tummy to mommy”) with her nose opposite your nipple. Gently support her head and shoulders with one hand. Her head and body should be in a straight line so that she doesn't have to twist to get to the nipple. Bring your baby close to your breast: her head should tilt back slightly, her chin touching your lower breast, and your nipple should be aimed toward the roof of her mouth, far closer to her top lip than the middle of her mouth. You can gently stroke her cheek with your finger or brush her nose/upper lip with your nipple, which will trigger her to open her mouth wide.



2 WAIT FOR A WIDE-OPEN MOUTH
Hold back until your baby's mouth is open very wide, as though she is yawning, before latching her on to your breast. This is crucial because she needs to suck on a good mouthful of your breast tissue. If she is sucking only on your nipple, it will be painful and cause breast-feeding problems.



3 LATCH HER ON
Once her mouth is open wide, quickly bring her onto the breast, bringing her whole body to you so she isn't craning forward. Aim your nipple toward the roof of her mouth, making sure it is well back in her mouth. If she has difficulty latching on, try using your thumb and forefinger in a U-shape to compress the nipple area a little, but don't press on the breast tissue too much.